colonial rule and extreme limitations in resourcing, India produced remarkable scientists who mattered on a global scale.

Later, universities brought high-powered incentives into the management of researchers. Universities demanded publication orientation from researchers. This was done by counting publications in general, and particularly valuing publications in ‘high-prestige journals’.

Once researchers were given career gains in return for publications, there was a strong incentive to increase the number of publications, even if this reduced the quality of research. In the extreme, ‘predatory journals’ have sprung up which exchange money for publications.

Similarly, many researchers choose projects which are likely to get into high-prestige journals, and have de-emphasized their own judgement about what is likely to be a fruitful line of inquiry. This is particularly harmful in social sciences and humanities, where scholars who are pursuing high-prestige journals outside India are likely to lose their engagement with the most important questions as seen in India.

Human networks are built to get into high-prestige journals, e.g., by befriending editors and referees, or finding co-authors who are well networked. Many research projects are constructed with Indian co-authors playing subsidiary roles, while co-authors abroad exert creative control.

Universities sought to spur research by creating high-powered incentives, such as jobs and promotions, in favour of publication in high-prestige journals. We now have more publications including those in high-prestige journals, but along the way we have paid a price in curiosity, creativity and innovation. We are pushing less important research into more prestigious journals. We should be more careful before unleashing high-powered incentives.

People’s responses to incentives can be wonky

Typically, we think that humans have unique preferences, that are hard for an outsider to understand, and each human pursues her own self-interest.